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IN MEMORY OF
NADA PROEVA (1949–2024)

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IN MEMORIAM

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National Museum of Serbia

IN MEMORY OF NADE PROEVA (1949-2024)



On the first anniversary of the death of Professor Nade Proeva (6 November 2024), the academic community respectfully remembers one of the foremost scholars of antiquity and the history of ancient Macedonia. Her passing has left a void in the scholarly world, but also an obligation to pay renewed tribute to her rich legacy, reputation, and contribution to society. Professor Proeva was an unquestioned authority and a trustworthy voice of historical truth. She was distinguished by dedication, methodological rigor, and the highest personal and professional integrity.

The academic path of Nade Proeva, born in Resen on 9 September 1949, was inextricably linked with Belgrade and its Faculty of Philosophy, where she received her professional formation. She graduated from the Department of Archaeology in 1973 and earned her master's degree in 1978; from her student days onward, she was active in the Centre for Ancient Epigraphy and Numismatics. She received her doctorate in 1992 from the Department of Ancient History, defending a dissertation entitled *The Influence of Immigrants on the Development of Cultural Processes in the Roman Province of Macedonia*, under the supervision of Academician Fanula Papazoglou. She continued her specialist training at the Sorbonne University in Paris, pursuing research in archaeology, epigraphy, numismatics, and Greco-Roman mythology (1979–1981).

During her career at the Institute of History, Faculty of Philosophy, Ss. Cyril and Methodius University in Skopje, she progressed through every academic rank, from lecturer to full professor (1984–2014). She educated several generations of accomplished scholars and, through her work, contributed greatly to the standing of historical scholarship.

Her research was grounded in a comprehensive study of the ancient Balkans, with a focus on Macedonia as an essential region of cultural and ethnic interconnections. Beginning with the earliest written sources from antiquity, Proeva examined the ethnic affiliation of tribal groups such as the Enchelei/Engelanes and the Dassaretae. Drawing on toponymy, onomastics, and, above all, the analysis of funerary rituals (as in the case of Trebenište), she sought to distinguish them from the purely Illyrian and Greek worlds and to place them within a specific Macedonian-Balkan context.

In the archaeology of Roman Macedonia, Proeva was particularly distinguished by her interpretation of funerary monuments. She is consequently regarded as the leading authority on a distinctive group of Roman epitaphs from Upper Macedonia known as the Tikveš stelae. Her research addressed their non-figural iconography (grapevine and ivy), chronology, and interpretation, and challenged earlier theories attributing them to Celtic, Oriental, or Manichaean origins. By interpreting the Tikveš stelae as a unique cultural and religious phenomenon, and their symbols as expressions of local cults, she demonstrated how these monuments manifested Dionysiac-Orphic mysticism and the indigenous custom of heroizing the deceased, thereby connecting their meanings with beliefs in immortality.

Ultimately, her research developed into a critical engagement with modern historiography, linking the ancient past with contemporary debates on ethnic identity in the Balkans.

Nade Proeva's scholarly oeuvre comprises more than one hundred studies, contributions, and articles. Among its most notable works are *Studies on the Ancient Macedonians* (1997), in which she advanced the thesis that the ancient Macedonians constituted a distinct ethnic group; *History of the Argeads* (2004), a textbook devoted to the first Macedonian royal dynasty and the first work of its kind in the Macedonian language; *Alexander of Macedon: Life and Work* (2013); and *The Religion of the Ancient Macedonians* (2014), a monograph offering her most comprehensive analysis of the Macedonian pantheon. That pantheon is known primarily through Greek sources interpreted through the prism of *interpretatio Graeca*, which created the erroneous impression of complete Hellenization, while the original Macedonian names were suppressed or preserved only in lexicographical traces.

Although most of her earlier works addressed antiquity, in *A Triptych for Macedonian Identity* (2018) she established a historical bridge, seeking to connect ancient and modern consciousness of Macedonian identity.

Nade Proeva was exceptionally committed to scholarly cooperation that transcended institutional and national boundaries. She participated in archaeological excavations in Macedonia, Serbia, Poland, and Greece; presented papers at numerous international conferences and colloquia; and undertook research stays at many academic centers. She was also a regular guest of the French School at Athens. She collaborated with several prestigious institutions, including the Institute of Archaeology in Belgrade, the Serbian Academy of Sciences and Arts, the Macedonian Academy of Sciences and Arts, and the Berlin-Brandenburg Academy of Sciences and Humanities. She also participated in major international projects,

including *Corpus Signorum Imperii Romani*, *Inscriptiones Graecae*, and *Epigraphical Sources for the History of Ancient Macedonia*.

As a recognized specialist in her field, she lectured at universities in France (Nancy and Paris Nanterre University), Croatia (Zagreb), Slovenia (Ljubljana), and other European countries, addressing subjects ranging from epigraphy and the ethnicity of the ancient Macedonians to modern myths. She also edited numerous publications (*Bibliotheca Historia antiqua Macedonica*; *Miscellanea Byzantino-macedonica*), served on the editorial board of *Radovi*, of the Institute of Croatian History published by the Faculty of Humanities and Social Sciences in Zagreb, and was a longstanding member of the editorial board of the *Recueil du Musée national - Archaeology series* (Belgrade). She was a loyal collaborator of the National Museum of Serbia and, above all, its sincere friend.

Professor Proeva was equally committed and effective in the popularization of history, participating actively in documentary programs and collaborating with the media. Her broad and thorough education enabled her to comment on contemporary issues in both academic circles and public life with full and undisputed authority.

Nade Proeva's outstanding contribution to scholarship received international recognition in 1997, when the French government awarded her the title of Chevalier dans l'Ordre des Palmes académiques.

In recognition of her scholarly work, several of her publications, *Studies of the Ancient Macedonians*, *History of the Argeads*; *Religion of the Ancient Macedonians* and *Triptych on the Macedonian Identity* will appear in English and be made available on line.

As an expression of gratitude and respect, her students prepared the collected volume *From Her Lectures in Our Words* and launched the website www.nadeproeva.net. A further tribute is planned by way of establishing a memorial room dedicated to her in Resen's Saraj Palace, one of Macedonia's most representative examples of Neo-Renaissance architecture. In addition, her family is working on the establishing of MACEDONICA- Center for Historical Studies 'Nade Proeva.'

An enduring testimony of remembrance is the memorial inscribed Nade Proeva / 1949–2024, erected at her grave in Skopje. The memorial was a gift from the Latvian artist Ernests Vītiņš, renowned for his work in layered glass. Its dignified, dynamic form and relief were achieved through the play of light and the material's rough texture. It is adorned with graphemes from four scripts: ancient Greek, Latin, Glagolitic, and modern Macedonian. Scattered across the surface, this collection of letters simultaneously forms the full name of the god and eponymous hero Makedon, the name Nade, and the initial letters of the Macedonian kings of the Argead dynasty. The symbolism of the memorial arises from the synergy between Nade Proeva's personal dedication and the subjects of her research, reflecting the breadth of her scholarly work from antiquity to the modern age.

Professor Nade Proeva continues to live through her work and through the generations of students whom she shaped. Her approach was comprehensive and holistic, and her legacy - founded on knowledge,

critical thought, and integrity - remains an essential source and a reliable guide for all scholars working in classical studies and in the ancient history of the Balkans and Macedonia.